GEMPEI WARS

MIZUSHIMA



Date November 17, 1183
Forces Minamoto: unknown; Taira: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location Between Honshu and Shikoku

Beginning in 1180, the Gempei Wars pitted the Minamoto samurai clan against the rival Taira clan in a struggle for control of Japan. In the summer of 1183 the Minamoto seized the upper hand in the civil war. Minamoto no Yoshimaka defeated the Taira at the battle of Kurikara and surrounded the imperial capital, Kyoto. The Taira were forced to flee and take refuge in their traditional power base in western Honshu and Shikoku, where they had a number of fortresses around the shores of the Inland Sea.

Taking the offensive, Minamoto no Yoshimaka sent an army to attack the Taira fortress at Yashima, a small island off the coast of Shikoku. The army was put under the command of a general, the unsophisticated Yada Yoshiyasu, since Yoshimaka himself was preoccupied with power struggles in his own clan.

The Minamoto army embarked at Mizushima on Honshu to cross the Inland Sea, but was surprised by a Taira fleet sent to intercept them. This force was commanded by Taira no Tomomori and Taira no Noritsune, experienced fighters with victories to their name. They ordered their ships to be tied together with hawsers at the stem and stern, and planks laid across them, so the whole fleet was a level surface for the samurai and their followers to fight on. The Taira then drew their bows and deluged the Minamoto ships with a rain of arrows. When the fighting came to close quarters, men attacked one another with swords and daggers, while some infantry with long rakes tried to pull enemy warriors into the water.

As the battle turned against him, Yada Yoshiyasu led a desperate foray forward with a few followers in a small boat, but the vessel was overturned and all aboard drowned. Desperate Minamoto soldiers splashed to shore through the shallows, but they were pursued by the Taira, who had horses on board their ships. The Taira horsemen rode down upon the Minamoto remnants and scattered them in flight. This spectacular victory could not prevent Yoshimaka from seizing Kyoto for the Minamoto the following year.



1152–1185

TAIRA NO TOMOMORI

COMMANDER OF THE FORCES OF THE TAIRA CLAN

The son of a famous father—the clan leader Taira no Kiyomori—Tomomori was the most successful of the Taira military commanders in the Gempei Wars. He won battles against the Minamoto on land at Uji in 1180 and Sunomata in 1181 and on the sea at Mizushima in 1183. Although primarily a soldier, he also seems to have possessed considerable experience in the use of ships in war. He committed suicide after the final defeat of the Taira at the sea battle of Dan-no-Ura, jumping into the water with an anchor tied to his feet.

GEMPEI WARS

YASHIMA



Date March 22,1185
Forces Minamoto: unknown; Taira: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location Yashima, off Shikoku

By 1185 Japan's Gempei Wars between the Minamoto and Taira clans were approaching their climax. Minamoto no Yoshitsune was pursuing the Taira in their last remaining fortresses in Shikoku. While crossing the Inland Sea, however, Yoshitsune ran into a storm and much of his fleet was lost. Although he was resupplied by his ally Kajiwara Kagetoki, he no longer had a clear advantage. By lighting hundreds of fires around the fortress of Yashima, Yoshitsune tricked the Taira into thinking that he had a much larger army. They abandoned the fortress, embarking on ships with their most precious possessions, the child emperor Antoku and the imperial treasure. As the Taira fled, one of the Minamoto samurai, Nasu no Yoichi, rode into the sea and shot a fan off the masthead of one of the departing ships—a celebrated feat of archery.



Aftermath of Yashima
Although most of the Taira escaped with the child emperor, some fell into the hands of the enemy. Here a Taira lady is discovered by Yoshitsune.

MONGOL–SONG WARS

XIANGYANG



Date 1268–1273
Forces Mongol Yuan: 5,000 ships; Song: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location Xiangfan, Hubei province, China

The Mongol warrior Kublai Khan made himself ruler of northern China in 1260, establishing the Yuan dynasty. The wealthy and populous lands of southern China, however, remained under the rule of the Song dynasty.

The Mongols were steppe horsemen with no knowledge of naval warfare, but in order to conquer the south they had to learn to fight on rivers and lakes. The lengthy struggle to reduce the fortified city of Xiangyang, held by the Song, was in effect a battle for control of the Han river, a major tributary of the Yangtze. Xiangyang was surrounded on three sides by mountains and on the fourth by the river. The Mongols had already realized the need for naval power in the conquest of the Song and recruited a vast fleet of river craft. This enabled them to impose a river blockade, as well as besieging Xiangyang by land. One Song flotilla managed to break through the blockade to resupply the city's defenders, but this was not enough to save Xiangyang. Once it fell, the Yuan fleet could sail down the river system to capture the major Song cities.

MONGOL–SONG WARS

YAMEN



Date March 19, 1279
Forces Mongol Yuan: unknown; Song: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location Guangdong, South China Sea

After years of stubborn resistance, in 1278 southern China, ruled for 300 years by the Song dynasty, was finally overrun by the armies of Kublai Khan, Mongol founder of the Yuan dynasty. The surviving officials and members of the Song imperial family became fugitives, seeking a base from which to begin organizing resistance. In March 1279 they were on board ship in a bay at Yamen, on the Guangdong coast, when they were located by a Yuan fleet under the command of Kublai's general Zhang Hongfan. The Song fleet and soldiers were commanded by grand general Zhang Shijie. Instead of advancing his ships to defend the mouth of the bay, which would have left the option of fleeing in case of defeat, Zhang Shijie adopted a passive formation inside the anchorage. He had his ships tied together and awaited the Yuan attack.



Mongol bowcase
The Mongols learned to use siege weapons to conquer the Song, but they still relied on the bows that brought them such success on the Asian steppe.

Zhang Hongfan first sent fire ships into the bay, but the Song coped successfully with this timeworn tactic. So the Yuan divided their fleet in order to attack from three directions. They were apparently heavily outnumbered by the Song, but their ships were equipped with primitive gunpowder weapons and stone-hurling catapults.

The Song soon lost heart. Zhang Shijie attempted to stage a breakout with a few ships carrying the seven-year-old emperor and the imperial entourage. When this failed, a senior official picked up the emperor and jumped overboard with the boy in his arms. Other officials and concubines followed his example. Zhang Shijie himself survived the battle but was drowned in a storm shortly after.